

Smokey Robinson was one of the leading American songwriters of the 1960s, known for the clever wordplay of his lyrics. One of his most famous songs is *The Tears of a Clown*, originally a hit in 1967.



Writing

A music review

1 What different kinds of music do you enjoy listening to, and in what situations? Who are your favourite singers/groups/composers?

2 Would you find the phrases below in a review of a concert, an album or both? Use the phrases to complete the reviews on p.25.

a masterful performance the opening act
deafening applause giving the audience 100%
highly acclaimed a powerful rendition
refreshingly new and different its appeal lies in
the atmosphere changed the encore
poignant final track voice is unmistakable
the legendary stands out

Macy Gray at the Roseland Ballroom

Macy Gray's show last Friday did not get off to an auspicious start. Technical difficulties, extra-strict security and an hour-long wait between

1) and Macy Gray's set made the audience impatient and rather listless.

However, the moment the singer and her band appeared,

2) from lethargic to electric.

Macy Gray came on in a shimmering red outfit and her 13-piece band were all dressed in white.

The show opened with 3) of *Do Something*, one of the most danceable tunes on the debut album *On How Life Is*, and suddenly everyone was on their feet dancing, as if pulled by a mysterious force.

Ms Gray went on to give 4), belting out her personal views on life, relationships and romance with a fiery passion. As well as the originals, she performed an array of cover versions which demonstrated her wide variety of musical influences. The best of these were the Beatles' *With a Little Help from my Friends* and Doris Day's *Que Sera Sera*. But whatever she sang, it was clear that Gray was 5) and was getting back the same. When the band finally launched into *I Try*, which they had saved until the end of 6), the crowd went wild and sang along enthusiastically and very loudly with all the choruses.

The show ended with 7) and chanting from fans demanding another encore, but Ms Gray has enough experience to know: always leave them wanting more. I know that I certainly did.



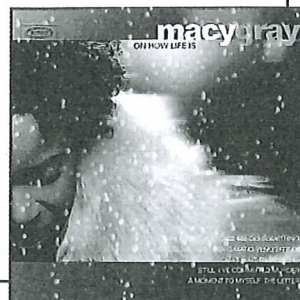
Artist: **Macy Gray**
Album: ***On How Life Is***
Label: **Sony**

The voice of Macy Gray is a wonderful thing. It can be sugar sweet on one song, harsh and scratchy on another. The obvious comparison is to 8) Billie Holiday, but there are traces of other influences too, such as Nina Simone and Tina Turner. Yet in the end, Macy Gray sounds like no one but herself: within ten seconds of any song on her debut album 9), *On How Life Is*, the 10)

Featuring confessional lyrics sung in a distinctive 'earthy' style, and a unique blend of hip hop, soul and rock, the album appeals across age and musical boundaries. It takes everything from breezy ballads to aggressive dance tunes and makes them sound 11) Of the ballads, the hit *I Try* definitely 12) : a hymn to the joy and pain of romantic dependence, part of 13) the catchy chorus, which showcases Gray's vocal talent. Other tracks which deserve a mention are the smoky ballad, *Still*, reminiscent of early Aretha Franklin, the comical *I've Committed Murder*, one of the album's up-tempo songs, and the 14), *The Letter*.

On How Life Is sounds like a drive through the neighbourhoods of contemporary Los Angeles: roll down your window, and you can hear Macy Gray's roots and her inspirations. And if you haven't got this inspiring album, drive on down to the record shop and buy it now.

Rating: ★★★★★



3 a) What information is contained in each paragraph of the two reviews?

b) Read again and find six more phrases which describe albums and concerts. Use these categories.

- 1 Songs/Tracks - cover versions
- 2 Voice
- 3 Audience
- 4 Concert - technical difficulties

4 a) Think of an album or concert that you have enjoyed recently and make notes on the following:

- the name(s) of the artist(s), the type of music
- reasons why you like the album or enjoyed the concert (e.g. the singer's voice, the atmosphere ...)
- descriptions of particularly good songs/tracks.

b) Write your review. Collect the reviews into a music guide for other students to read.